
A Spatial Network Study of Itinerant Performers' Passports in 18th- and 19th-Century France

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Abstract

Long confined to local or typological monographs, the study of fairground shows and curiosities in 18th- and 19th-century France (puppets, acrobatics, street music, optical demonstrations, circuses, etc.) is currently undergoing a major historiographical renewal (Triolaire et al., 2023). This is based in particular on the use of previously unpublished sources, including domestic passports. These passports, which were compulsory for much of the 19th century, make it possible to trace population movements, particularly those of individuals who made their living from traveling shows (Daniel, 2020; Bourdin et Triolaire, 2024). These internal passports, administered systematically and on a massive scale, are now unevenly preserved and scattered throughout France (municipal, departmental, and national archives). The result of a collaborative effort involving academics, independent researchers, and non-academics (genealogists, collectors), the "Spectacles de curiosités" database (<https://spectacle-de-curiosites.msh.uca.fr/>) allows users to track the movements of some 17,000 people (Daniel and Vasile, 2023). From these passports, 38,000 records were extracted, enabling 60,000 journey segments to be reconstructed (Daniel and Grandjean, 2026).

This study aims to show that historical network analysis (Grandjean, 2021; 2025) can be used to leverage this database to document the mobility of these individuals in two ways:

Using network analysis to cross-match individual trajectories to identify individuals who were recorded multiple times in the same locations on the same day (fig. 1). This approach makes it possible to reconstruct groups of itinerant performers who are on a joint tour. While it appears that, overall, individuals are only loosely connected, we have identified about a hundred groups of people who are often present in the same places at the same time. For some of these groups, their shared geographic origin or the type of performance seem to explain why they travel together; for others, we have discovered that they share family ties.

Using network analysis to draw a global map of the movements of itinerant performers across France (fig. 2). This approach makes it possible to understand the spatiality of this phenomenon and to study its seasonal logic. Although the results are heavily skewed by the influence of cities with particularly large amounts of preserved passport funds, a network of cities emerges, confirming the importance of certain routes.

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This allows us to make assumptions about the complementary nature of the various performing arts, the sociability of these professions, and the importance of family ties. This also makes it possible to place individual trajectories in the context of the main pathways, to see which prosopographic characteristics correlate with which types of journeys.

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Figure 1. Network of itinerant performers who have been repeatedly recorded on the same day at the same location. Both figures were created using Gephi (Bastian et al., 2009).

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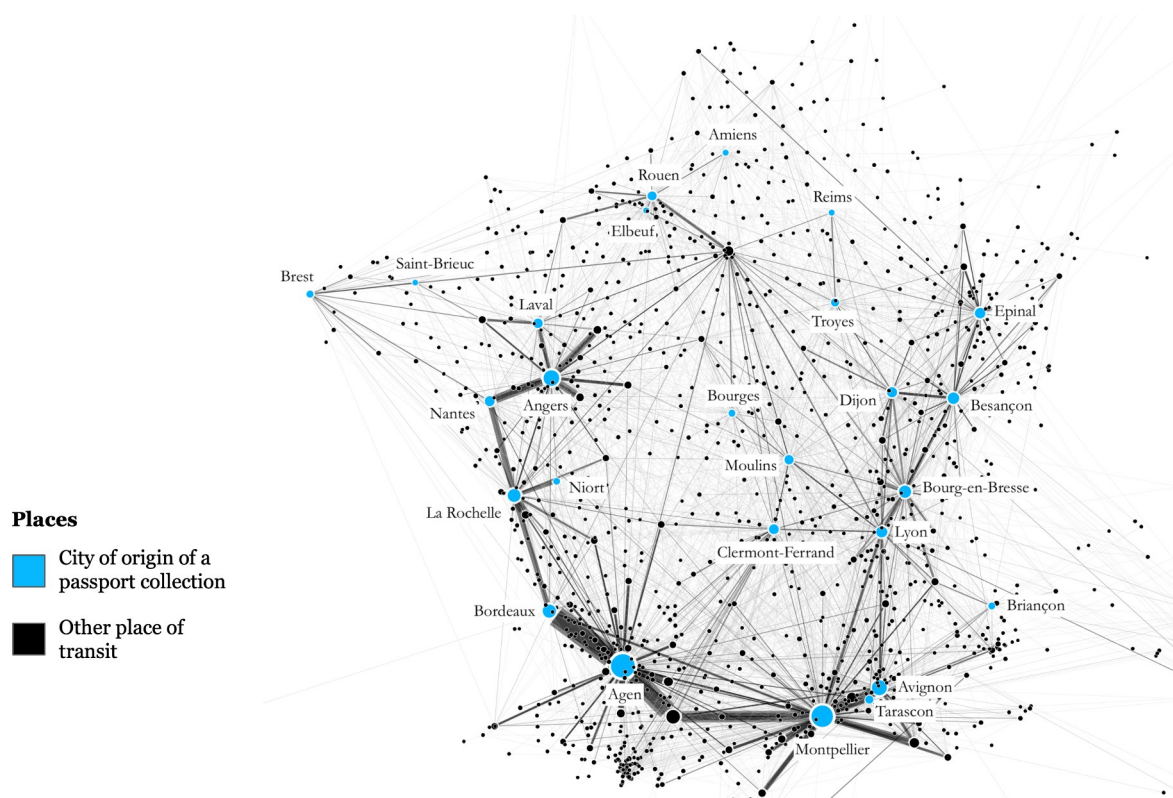


Figure 2. Map aggregating the chains of places of passage recorded in the passports of itinerant performers.